



First-Time Homebuyer Checklist



**Buying your first home can feel overwhelming,
but knowing what to expect can make the process much easier.**

Before You Start Shopping

- ☐ Review your credit report and dispute any inaccuracies if appropriate
- ☐ Decide what monthly housing payment feels comfortable for your budget
- ☐ Start saving for your down payment
- ☐ Plan for closing costs, moving expenses, and emergency savings
- ☐ Avoid making major financial changes before speaking with your lender

Get Your Financing Ready

- ☐ Speak with a licensed mortgage professional about available financing options
- ☐ Gather the income, asset, and identification documents your lender requests
- ☐ Ask whether you may qualify for first-time buyer or down payment assistance programs
- ☐ Get pre-approved before seriously shopping for homes
- ☐ Review your estimated monthly payment, cash needed to close, and other potential costs

Start Your Home Search

- ☐ Make a list of your must-haves and nice-to-haves
- ☐ Identify the areas and neighborhoods you want to explore
- ☐ Consider commute, property taxes, insurance, HOA fees, and other ongoing expenses
- ☐ Work with a real estate professional who understands your goals
- ☐ Take notes during home tours so you can compare properties later

Before Making an Offer

- ☐ Review recent comparable sales with your real estate professional
- ☐ Discuss your offer price and overall strategy
- ☐ Understand any contingencies included in your offer
- ☐ Know how much earnest money may be required
- ☐ Review the estimated cash you may need for the transaction
- ☐ Discuss the risks of changing or waiving contingencies before making a decision





Once You're Under Contract

- ❑ Complete inspections you choose to include in the transaction
- ❑ Review available property disclosures and inspection findings
- ❑ Respond promptly to requests from your lender and other transaction professionals
- ❑ Complete the appraisal process if required by your lender
- ❑ Arrange homeowners insurance when applicable
- ❑ Avoid opening new credit accounts, financing major purchases, changing jobs, or moving large amounts of money without first discussing it with your lender

Before Closing

- ❑ Review your final loan and settlement documents carefully
- ❑ Confirm the amount and approved method for sending closing funds
- ❑ Complete your final walkthrough
- ❑ Bring any required identification or documentation
- ❑ Ask questions about anything you do not understand before signing
- ❑ Sign your closing documents
- ❑ Get the keys 🗝️🎉

A Quick Reminder

Your down payment is only one part of buying a home.

Depending on the transaction, you may also need to plan for closing costs, inspections, property taxes, homeowners insurance, HOA fees, moving expenses, repairs, and emergency savings.

Knowing these costs ahead of time can help you prepare with fewer surprises.

Disclaimer: This checklist is provided for general educational and informational purposes only and is not intended as legal, tax, financial, lending, or other professional advice. Loan programs, qualification requirements, assistance programs, costs, timelines, and real estate procedures may vary based on the buyer, property, lender, location, and transaction. Buyers should consult the appropriate licensed professionals for advice specific to their situation.

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